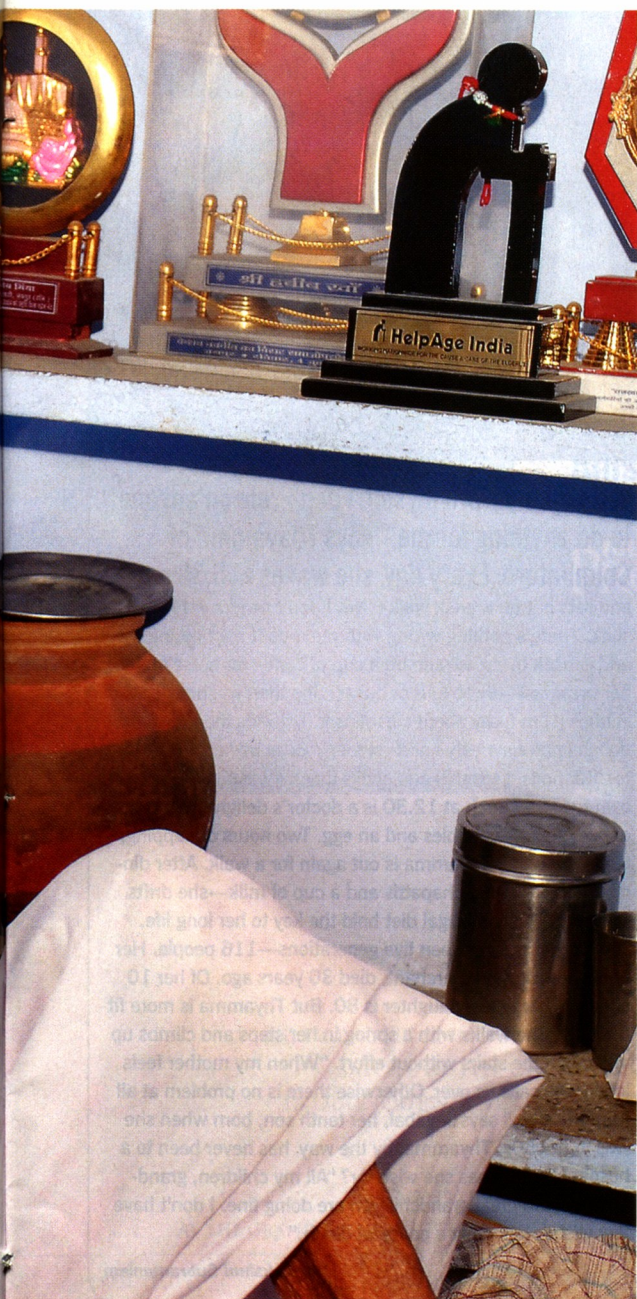


ARIANS

In an age of fast foods and fizzy drinks, the experiences of six centenarians have much to teach us about how to keep the body fit and the mind active and young



127 years HABIB MIAN

Clarinet player, Jaipur

"You treat your body well, the body treats you well, too," says India's oldest (reportedly) centenarian, who breaks into puns and quips at the drop of a hat. His bank says he is 127-years-old. But his family tree, a blurry parchment in Urdu, marks 1869 to be his year of birth. That makes him as old as Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi. And as old as the Suez Canal. Habib Mian lives at Ghat ki Guni, near the famous heritage garden, Sisodia Rani ka Bagh on Agra Road in Jaipur city. The burden of age may have taken away his vision, but not his enthusiasm for life. He recently questioned a bank clerk why he was being asked to nominate someone when he had no intention of dying any time soon.

"My teeth are intact. In fact, they fall and grow back. This is the third time," he claims. He loves to talk, recite Tulsidas and fondly recalls the first movie he watched, *Kimti Ansu* in 1927. And he loves food. "*Chicken roti khao, allah ke gun gayo*," (Eat chicken-chapatti and praise the Lord) he rolls with glee. Mian eats one *desi* ghee parantha in the morning and at night. A glass of milk in the afternoon is a must and four to six cups of tea. And he looks forward to his favourite meal of korma and kalakand every Sunday. His favourite memory is buying kalakand for one *paisa* in his youth. The secret of his long life? "No addiction—tobacco or liquor."

Son of a bhishtiwallah, he helped out as a stable hand, became a clarinet player and retired as a band master from the erstwhile Jaipur royalty. He did his daily chores on his own until last year when he fractured his knee. He lives with his family of 26, across six generations, who are now trying to put him up for the *Guinness Book of World Records* as the oldest man in the world. Old age has brought him kudos: an 'Aabe-e-Jaipur' (Lustre of Jaipur) from the mayor and mention in the *Limca Book of Records*. His biggest moment was when President A.P.J. Abdul Kalam visited him last April.

by Rohit Parihar

Why are you asking me to name a nominee?
I have no intention of dying soon.

HABIB MIAN GHAT KI GUNI, JAIPUR

PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR